

NIGHTMARE HUNTERS

Many deepwater fish are predators with huge mouths, long needlelike teeth, super-acute senses, and enormous stretchable stomachs. Some even have spotlights to locate their targets, or luminous lures to tempt them within range. They need these extreme adaptations because prey is so hard to find. Once a hunter has found a victim, it must make sure it doesn't get away.

FAST FACTS

- Some parts of the deep ocean lie more than 6 miles (10 km) below the waves.
- Water deeper than 0.6 miles (1 km) is pitch dark except for luminous animals.
- Almost 200,000 species of animals have been found living on the deep ocean floor.
- The deep ocean floor is so remote that we know more about the surface of the Moon.



▲ DEATH TRAP

Meals are scarce in the deep. This ferocious viperfish plunges its long teeth deep into its victims so they cannot escape.



DEEP OCEAN FLOOR

Far below the surface lies the dark, cold world of the deep ocean floor. Most of the animals that live here feed on dead animals and plankton drifting down from above. They include debris-feeders like this sea cucumber, scavengers such as the slimy hagfish, and hunters such as rat-tail fish and chimeras. There are also anemones and worms that spend their lives attached to rocks or burrowing in soft mud.

CHEMICAL ENERGY

Volcanically active parts of the ocean floor are dotted with black smokers—rocky vents that gush hot, chemically rich water. Special microbes use the chemical energy to make food. Communities of crabs, clams, and giant tube worms crowd around the vents. They are among the few living things on the planet that do not rely on the energy of sunlight.

RED PLUMES ►

This view from a deep-ocean research vehicle shows a cluster of giant tube worms, with plumes of red gills extending from their white tubes.

